



A POPULARITY CONTEST IS NOT A BUDGET

BERKELEY DESERVES PRIORITIES. NOT JUST MORE PRIORITIES.



BERKELEY IS FACING A FISCAL REALITY.

-  Persistent structural deficit
-  Hundreds of millions in unfunded liabilities
-  Deferred infrastructure and maintenance
-  Looking at new taxes to sustain services

YET EVERY YEAR, WE FUND THOUSANDS OF GOOD THINGS.



Good intentions aren't the problem.
The problem is how we decide what comes first.

THE CURRENT PROCESS REWARDS VISIBILITY, NOT PRIORITY.

-  The best organized constituency wins.
-  Many programs are funded without clear outcomes.
-  Outside money is pursued without weighing the full cost to Berkeley.
-  Once started, programs rarely end.

A BETTER WAY TO DECIDE: 6 QUESTIONS EVERY DOLLAR MUST ANSWER

Scarce local dollars should earn their place.

1

IS THIS A CORE CITY RESPONSIBILITY?



Focus on what local government is uniquely responsible for—not everything that's important.

EXAMPLE TEST:
If Berkeley didn't do this, who would?

2

IS IT MORE IMPORTANT THAN COMPETING NEEDS?



Every dollar has an opportunity cost. What are we not doing with this money?

EXAMPLE TEST:
What would we have to cut or delay to pay for this?

3

DOES IT WORK—AND HOW WOULD WE KNOW?



Good intentions aren't enough. Expect measurable results and regular evaluation.

EXAMPLE TEST:
What is the outcome? How will we measure it? What's the plan if it doesn't work?

4

DOES OUTSIDE FUNDING ACTUALLY REDUCE OUR BURDEN?



Free money isn't free if it creates ongoing costs, obligations, service magnet effects, or harder exit ramps.

EXAMPLE TEST:
Will this leave Berkeley owning the problem long-term?

5

WHO ELSE SHOULD BE PAYING OR PARTICIPATING?



If a need is regional or shared, the solution and the cost should be shared too.

EXAMPLE TEST:
Are we solving a regional problem with local dollars alone?

6

WHEN DO WE STOP, SHRINK, OR REDESIGN IT?



Funding something once should not create a permanent entitlement.

EXAMPLE TEST:
What's the review date? What would cause us to sunset, scale back, or change course?

HOW WE USE LOCAL DOLLARS MATTERS

HIGH PRIORITY USES

Keep Berkeley safe, functional and financially sound.

 PUBLIC SAFETY

 ROADS & INFRASTRUCTURE

 FACILITIES & MAINTENANCE

 FISCAL STABILITY & RESERVES

THEN CONSIDER

After core needs are met and proven.

 GRANTS & SUBSIDIES

 ARTS & CULTURE

 ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

 ADVOCACY & SYMBOLIC PROGRAMS

NOT NEVER. NOT BAD. JUST NOT FIRST.

Good things still deserve consideration—in the right order, with the right evidence, and with clear limits.



A BETTER BERKELEY BUDGET STARTS WITH DISCIPLINE.

-  Ask every budget item the same six questions.
-  Rank needs honestly. Make trade-offs explicit.
-  Fund what matters most. Measure results. Adjust.

OUR VALUES AREN'T THE PROBLEM.
OUR PRIORITIES ARE.

Let's budget like we mean it.

Responsible today. Sustainable tomorrow. 